

Foreword

by Judith Miller

The lure of precious stones and gems is universal – it is common to every age and every culture. From the moment a sparkling mineral first caught the eye of a caveman, humans have been fascinated by the wonders of the earth beneath their feet, and have marvelled at the different ways that stones and crystals react with the light, at their varied properties and uses, and at the way that they appear miraculously transformed when cut and polished.

This appeal goes far beyond visual beauty – throughout history, mysterious powers have been ascribed to certain gems and minerals. Healers deemed some gems to have medicinal qualities, while astrologers and alchemists utilized others; the sacred texts of major religions mentioned precious stones, and jewels frequently featured in ritual practices. Some Chinese emperors, for example, were buried in jade suits, in the belief that this stone conferred a form of immortality; similarly, the precious gems and metals used in the complex burial rites of Egyptian pharaohs were designed to ease their passage into the afterlife.

Many jewels have become woven into the fabric of national mythologies. In Australia, opals feature prominently in enchanting creation stories, which are set in the Dreamtime of the Aboriginal peoples. In Britain, meanwhile, there is a colourful legend surrounding one of the oldest stones in the Crown Jewels, St Edward's sapphire – according to tradition, this jewel came from a ring worn by Edward the Confessor, who generously gave it to a beggar. Many years later, the stranger returned it to him, joyously revealing that he was no beggar, but John the Evangelist and that Edward would soon be joining him in Paradise.

Sometimes, an entire industry could arise from a gemstone's associations, typified by the links between jet and mourning. This sleek, black substance was scattered on funeral pyres in Bronze-Age burials and the Romans were also fond of using it. The gem went out fashion for a time, but enjoyed a resurgence in popularity in the 19th century: Queen Victoria wore jet adornments throughout her long years of mourning for Prince Albert, and her example was followed by other widows in Britain. For